company’s payroll office if you can have a fixed sum taken from each paycheck—say, $50 a month—and funneled directly into your savings account. If your employer doesn’t provide automatic savings, set up a transfer to a savings or mutual fund account through your bank website. (See Chapter 5 for more on mutual funds.) If you set aside $50 every two weeks, at the end of the year you’ll have $1,300—plus interest!

- **Have *savings* automatically deducted from your account.** The old adage is “pay yourself first,” meaning you should contribute to your monthly savings just as diligently as you pay your monthly bills. And one of the smartest ways to do that is to make your savings automatic. Because you don’t see the money that’s being set aside, before long you won’t even miss it. There are a couple of ways to do this: Ask your company’s payroll office if you can have a fixed sum taken from each paycheck—say, $50 a month—and funneled directly into your savings account. If your employer doesn’t provide automatic savings, set up a transfer to a savings or mutual fund account through your bank website. (See Chapter 5 for more on mutual funds.) If you set aside $50 every two weeks, at the end of the year you’ll have $1,300—plus interest!

- **To help control spending, use online budgeting tools.** Truth is, if your financial life is fairly simple, you probably don’t want to bother with anything more than your bank’s online account services to keep tabs on your money. But if you have a more complicated situation, budgeting websites can help. Free sites like www.mint.com or www.wesabe.com or www.quickenonline.com make it easy for you to calculate what portion of your income goes to various categories, such as “housing,” “clothes,” and “dining out.” If you had a grand time filling out my worksheet earlier in the chapter, these sites could help you hone in even more on where your money is going. At the end of a few months you can see how much you spent in each category, and you might learn